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Section Title(S)

Approved marriages • Polygynous marriages

Approved marriages

No marriages are compulsory in !Kung society.

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Regulation Of Marriage

602
Kin Relationships

Marriage is allowed with anyone to whom the incest taboo is not extended— with three degrees of approval: preference, permission, and toleration. Once a marriage has taken place, no differentiation in status is made.

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Kin Relationships

The joking relationship is the differentiating factor between the preference and mere permission which the society accords. In preferred marriages the man and woman are name relatives who have had the joking relationship before marriage and have applied to each other the terms *!gu!na* and *tũn*. This makes the marriage seem altogether right.

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Kin Relationships

Marriage is permitted between name relatives who apply the terms *tsu* and *//ga* to each other and avoided joking before marriage, provided the incest taboo is not specifically extended to them; and, in the same way, marriage is

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permitted between name relatives who apply to each other the terms *!go*, brother, and *!kwi*, sister.

Kin Relationships

Marriage is tolerated, though rarely experienced, as I mentioned before, with persons to whom the name relationship and the application of kin terms is not extended; i.e. persons of other races, persons of other Bushman language groups, or other !Kung outside the region.

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To contract a marriage with someone with whom one must not joke brings in a touch of the anomalous which deprives the !Kung of the perfect symmetry and consistency which so content them and make them feel secure in rightness. This society tolerates the anomaly, for obviously it must not forbid marriage in too many categories, and adjusts the joking status by giving to man and wife the joking relationship as soon as marriage takes place.

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Family Relationships

Though neither the sororate nor the levirate is compulsory, marriage is highly approved with the wife of a deceased brother or the husband of a sister. A man is expected to take care of his BrWi should she need his care, even though he is not required to marry her. Marriage with a WiSi or HuBr is also highly approved. Ego has had the joking relationship with these affines.

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Secondary Marriages

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A marriage arrangement which the !Kung consider especially good is called *!oa ku*. This means that an exchange is made between two bands: a boy and girl from one marry a girl and boy from the other. *!Oa ku* is not a common practice. Bands as units have no authority in the arrangements of marriages, which is the duty of the parents, as we shall describe presently, and parents do not make the exchange between bands a major factor in their choices. If it happens to come about, however, the people are glad because each band thereby gains a person to replace the person lost and the bonds between the bands are strengthened.

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Polygynous marriages

Polygyny is the ideal form of marriage among the !Kung. This is not a society in which prestige and wealth concentrate to give certain categories of men more power or right than others to acquire wives. Headmen and medicine

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Property In Movables

men are held in esteem, but their positions do not in themselves entitle them to have extra wives or give them special dispensations. Wealth tends to be fairly well equalized. Everyone carries his or her own artifacts, the men on carrying-sticks over their shoulders, the women  346 in the pouches of their karosses along with their babies. This puts a strict limit upon any desire to possess great quantities of property in movables. Furthermore, gift-giving keeps all personal property moving in a current through the region and no one possesses very much more than another. The determining factors in obtaining more than one wife are apt to be the personalities of the individuals and the man's ability to hunt. 'Women love meat', we were told, and like their husbands to be good hunters.

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